Emotions and feelings

The same red can awaken **fear** in one of us and **desire** in another – sometimes even both in one day.

Red can awaken energy, courage, joy, passion and desire, but also rage, tension, shame, envy or a feeling of threat. It is not that the colour has **one fixed effect**. We respond to it with **our body, experience, culture and the situation** in which we meet it.

Emotions

Quick, strong reactions that can appear in an instant.

Fear and threat

Red can trigger **alertness**, **tension** or the need to **stop**. The body seems to say. **Careful, something is going on here**.

And why?

It is linked with **blood**, **warning**, **traffic lights**, **prohibition** and **error**. We have learned these meanings culturally too. For some people red therefore draws attention pleasantly, while for others it quickly opens up **a feeling of threat**.

Ask yourself

"When does red feel like a warning or a prohibition to me?"

Anger and defiance

It can bring out **rage**, **resistance**, **determination** and **the urge to say no**. Sometimes it is pure anger, at other times **energy that finally defends a boundary**.

And why?

In strong agitation the body is flushed with blood, the pulse speeds up and the face may turn red. Red has also long been used as a colour of **protest, struggle and strength**. That is why it can work as a visual **"enough"**.

Try asking yourself

"What is hiding under my anger – tiredness, pain, helplessness, or a sense of injustice?"

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Joy and excitement

Red can bring **a spark**, **zest for life**, **anticipation** and **a kick-start**. It is that feeling when something is finally happening.

And why?

It is striking, quickly catches attention and recalls **fire, warmth and movement**. The brain therefore easily reads it as something **alive and active**. In a good mood it can really "kick us into gear".

If I asked you now

"When does red charge you up, and when does it stop being fun?"

Desire and sexual arousal

It can evoke **attraction**, **desire**, **passion** and **physical arousal** – but just as easily **shame** or **embarrassment**.

And why?

With arousal the body changes. The pulse quickens, the skin flushes and the lips and cheeks may turn red. On top of that came cultural images of red lips, dresses, roses and lingerie. Red thus became a strong **shorthand for eroticism and attraction**.

Ask yourself

"Does red feel sexy, cheeky, flirtatious, or something else entirely?"

Feelings and experience

Less immediate than emotions. They say more about how we feel in red with ourselves and among people.

Being seen

Red can bring **confidence** and **joy in attention**, but also **embarrassment**, **shame** or a feeling of **"I am too much"**.

And why?

Red draws the eye faster than many muted colours. If we have learned to be inconspicuous, this may be exactly what feels unpleasant. It is not necessarily the colour that bothers us – **what bothers us is the feeling that we are suddenly visible**.

A question for you

"Do you enjoy it when someone turns to look at you, or does it rather unsettle you?"

Closeness and love

Red can feel like **warmth**, **an embrace**, **tenderness** and **closeness**. The same colour can also open **an old pain** or **a wound**.

And why?

For centuries we have linked it with the heart, roses, love and celebrations of relationships. That is why it can bring up not only lovely memories but also those in which **closeness was tied to disappointment**.

If I asked you now

"Do you connect red with love and romance? Or rather with pain?"

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Strength and courage

In red we can feel **firmer**, **more decisive** and **readier to act**. At other times it can feel like **pressure**. You must be strong, you must cope with something.

And why?

Red recalls fire, blood in the veins and a quickened pulse – that is, a state in which the body is **ready for action**. That is why we easily link it with **strength**, **performance** and **courage**.

Ask yourself

"What would I allow myself in red that I do not allow myself otherwise?"

Sensuality and relationship to the body

Sometimes red works quite quietly. Lipstick, underwear, a scarf or a detail **that mainly we ourselves know about**. It can bring a feeling of **femininity**, **sensuality** and **"this is mine"**.

And why?

It is not a magical property of the colour. Red works as a **personal signal** and a **cultural symbol**. When we link it with the body, femininity or attraction, it can remind us of **our own physicality** without a single outside glance.

A question for you

"Do you have something red that you wear only for yourself?"

My red is not the same as your red

A colour itself **experiences nothing**. **We experience it.** When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), **the experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes **a shortcut**. One glimpse is enough and the body knows whether it can relax or should pull back. That is why **your own reaction** always matters more than a universal dictionary of colours.

- **Red lipstick**
  For one woman it is mum and festive moments, for another something that was not allowed.
- **Red pencil**
  For one it is praise, for another a crossing-out and shame at school.
- **Rose**
  Love and romance, or an obligatory bouquet and embarrassment.
- **Siren and flashing lights**
  A feeling that help is coming, or a moment when your stomach clenches.
- **Red mug from home**
  Warmth and a morning at the table, or a home you wanted to get away from.

Why does it attract me even though I am actually afraid of it?

Perhaps it does not express how you feel. Perhaps you are drawn to what **you lack**. After a long period when you held back, red can remind you that you may take up space, have appetite and be seen. It can also be attractive because it gives you a feeling of strength, even if you cannot yet carry all of it. Try it first in a small detail and watch whether it gives you courage or rather unsettles you.

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Why does it seem unpleasant to me, on the contrary?

A strong red is **too loud** for you. It reminds you of **prohibition**, **shouting** or an environment where you were far too exposed. If you have long **had to endure pressure**, its urgency may remind you of a role you no longer want to play. Aversion to red does not have to mean you reject strength or passion. Maybe you are only rejecting another **duty to be on guard all the time**. Try to tell whether all red bothers you or only a certain form of it. Burgundy can be beautiful even if you do not want a bright red wall even in a photograph.

When to add it and when to take it away

Add it where it pleases you and opens something pleasant. Take it away when you catch yourself **looking away from it**, everything seems too strong or you finally want fewer stimuli. Notice the changes. **Brick red does me good**, bright scarlet disturbs me. In winter it draws me more than in summer. In a painting I want it big, in clothes I do not yet feel at ease in it. These are your concrete experiences. They do not have to fit into one answer, **“I like red”**.

If I asked you now

Has my relationship with red changed with age?

What does red in a room awaken in you? Try to remember whether you have seen it somewhere in someone's room. How did you feel there?

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